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Unified messaging, as it stands today, brings together several existing Internet technologies. As a result, most of the standards that have been instituted for data-based networks will also carry voice data in the future as telecom networks move towards data transfer.

Where's UM headed?

UM is quite prevalent in the West and gaining ground even in India. Earlier, fax, voice mail, and e-mail servers were installed discretely, being separate entities, and each operated only within its own area of responsibility. Today, these services are all integrated into one system that acts as a repository for collecting various messages and are comfortably operated from one user interface, known as the UMS, that offers enormous advantages in the field of business communications.

The unified inbox that we have today is set to evolve into an intelligent messaging network that will allow communication via wired or wireless devices. You will be able to send and receive messages without having to worry about how the recipient will view or hear them. Recipients in turn will be able to choose to check their messages via the medium they are comfortable with.

The system will be able to search intelligently and locate you easily whether you are logged into your messaging service or are only accessible via messages sent to your pager. Voice applications built around speech engines will make it possible for you to access any information you need at any time. Businesses will be at the forefront of this change as they search for solutions to the challenges of making it possible for employees separated by time and space to work together to capitalise on opportunities available to them.

Unified messaging as it stands today is a combination of several existing Internet technologies. Most standards such as HTTP, SMTP, POP3 and SSL form the foundation of most existing UMSs. Software architecture has also moved towards integration with Sun's Java programming language and the recently introduced Microsoft.Net, making it possible for applications to run on different platforms.

But this is not the case in areas such as wireless communication and speech processing. Another major issue is that telecom infrastructure in various parts of the world adhere to different standards.



Some popular services you can avail of:

www.onebox.com
For free voicemail, fax and e-mail in one place

www.etouch.com
Provides IP-based solutions for unified messaging

www.j2.com
Voicemail, fax and the works

www.ureach.com
Your integrated communications tool

www.hotvoice.com
Connecting through gateways

www.yac.com
You are always connected, what else?

The Japanese iMode network is more advanced than the GSM networks that are currently in use in India. To enable the move from the existent unified messaging to unified communications, networks of the future will need to adopt a common standard that will allow data to flow seamlessly through all of them.